



ANALYSIS REPORT

MOGADISHU, SOMALIA

Somali National University Faculty of Education

Why Students Are Not Choosing to Enrol in the Faculty and
What Prevents Those Who Enrol from Completing Their
Programmes.



PREPARED BY

Somali National University
in partnership with Hindis

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ABBREVIATIONS

FGD	Focus Group Discussion
HINDIS	Education organisation partnering with SNU on this study
KII	Key Informant Interview
MoECHE	Ministry of Education, Culture and Higher Education
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
SNU	Somali National University
β	Standardized regression coefficient (strength of a statistical effect)

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This research is conducted as a partnership between Somali National University (SNU) and Hindis. It examines a key challenge facing SNU's Faculty of Education: why students are not enrolling in education programmes, and why some of those who do enroll fail to complete their studies. The report synthesizes three focus group discussions and five key informant interviews with current students, alumni, faculty leadership and administrative staff, alongside peer-reviewed literature and MoECHE teacher recruitment data for 2023–2024.

The analysis identifies negative community perceptions of teaching, financial pressure, inadequate laboratory and library resources, heavy early-semester workload and weak career visibility as the principal barriers to enrolment and retention. It also identifies real institutional strengths: qualified and supportive lecturers, effective awareness programmes, affordable public provision, and emerging government employment pathways. The recommendations that follow are directed at MoECHE, SNU and national leadership, on the basis that strengthening the teaching profession requires coordinated action rather than action by the faculty alone.

37%

National literacy rate, with fewer than half of primary-age children enrolled

9.6%

Of successful MoECHE teaching candidates in Cohort 2 held an education degree, down from 25.9%

12%

Of students entered the Faculty as a first choice out of passion for teaching

1. Introduction and Background

Somali National University (SNU) is Somalia's only public national university and its oldest institution of higher learning. Founded in Mogadishu in 1954 under the Italian trusteeship administration, it obtained full university status in 1969 and grew into a large multi-faculty institution that educated much of the country's civil service. The collapse of central government and the outbreak of civil war in 1991 forced the university to close for more than two decades. SNU reopened in August 2014 as part of the broader effort to rebuild Somalia's public institutions and develop the human capital needed for national recovery. The Faculty of Education was re-established at the same time, continuing the teacher preparation mandate previously carried by Lafoole College, which had trained secondary school teachers from 1963 until the war.

As the faculty of Somalia's only public university charged with preparing teachers, its difficulty in attracting and retaining students carries consequences beyond the institution. Somalia's literacy rate stands at 37 percent and fewer than half of primary school-age children are enrolled (Mohamed, 2022), making the supply of professional educators a national priority. Yet the Faculty continues to face low enrolment, driven by the poor standing of teaching as a profession and by low salaries.

This study was initiated as a partnership between SNU and Hindis, an education organization working on foundational learning and system-level education reform in Somalia, to understand why students are not choosing to enroll in the Faculty and what prevents those who enroll from completing their programmes. It draws on three focus group discussions and five key informant interviews with current students, alumni, faculty leadership and administrative staff, six scholarly articles, and MoECHE recruitment data from 2023 to 2024. Its findings are intended to inform the Faculty's Strategic Enrollment Plan.

2. Methodology

2.1 DATA COLLECTION

The study used a mixed qualitative and quantitative approach, combining focus group discussions, key informant interviews, and a review of MoECHE teacher recruitment data. These methods were selected because decisions to enroll in and remain on an education programme are shaped by perceptions and personal circumstances best surfaced through discussion, while the scale of the gap between education graduates and actual teaching employment can only be established from recruitment data. Fieldwork was conducted at SNU in July 2026. Three focus group discussions were held: one with ten current students, one with eight alumni, and a combined student–alumni discussion with fourteen participants. Five key informant interviews were conducted with two alumni, two administrative staff members, and the Dean of the Faculty of Education. Each was audio recorded with participant permission, transcribed verbatim, and anonymised.



PLATE 1 A key informant interview in progress with faculty leadership at Somali National University, Mogadishu, July 2026.

2.2 LITERATURE REVIEW

The review draws on six peer-reviewed articles, selected primarily from countries neighboring Somalia or with comparable education contexts in the Horn of Africa and the wider Middle East and North Africa region. These share the conditions that shape teacher education in Somalia, including conflict or post-conflict recovery, constrained public

financing, and a persistent shortage of qualified teachers, making their lessons more plausibly transferable than those drawn from high-income systems. See et al. (2022) reviewed international evidence on teachers' career choice; Mohamed (2022) examined strategies for building a professional Somali teaching force; Opoku et al. (2025) investigated attitudes towards teaching and retention in Egypt and the United Arab Emirates; Mousse and Mosisa (2026) reviewed the effects of conflict and displacement on learning outcomes in the Horn of Africa; Omar et al. (2025) examined quality assurance in post-conflict Somali higher education; and Moses et al. (2022) reviewed teacher education and student teachers' commitment to teaching.

2.3 QUANTITATIVE DATA ANALYSIS

MoECHE teacher recruitment data for 2023–2024 was analysed to establish state-level recruitment trends. Applicant and successful candidate figures were disaggregated by gender and by whether candidates held an education degree, across two recruitment cohorts. These results were used to test and extend the qualitative findings.

3. Findings

3.1 STUDENT MOTIVATION AND ENROLLMENT PATTERNS

Interviews indicate that the Faculty of Education is rarely a first choice. Most participants were admitted to Education after being unsuccessful in their preferred programmes. One current student described the moment of admission:

“This faculty was not my first choice, my first choice was Economics, and I was not happy when I was accepted to Education because people think that that’s just about holding chalk and teaching.”

CURRENT STUDENT FGD, R6

An alumnus described a similar route into the Faculty after finding the programme they had chosen was already full (Alumni 2 KII). This pattern is structural. Students apply to three faculties and a nine-member committee allocates places according to entrance examination performance. An administrative staff member explained that a faculty like Medicine “could have 1000 students coming in, the first choice being Medicine, but for you, it could be 10 first

choice students” (Administrative Staff KII), and noted that the Faculty may begin with only a handful of first-choice applicants yet eventually enroll more than 200 students redirected from other programmes.

Many students nonetheless described a change of attitude after enrolling. One recalled that lecturers organised awareness workshops explaining each department, its importance, and the career and postgraduate options available (Current Student FGD, R6). Another, who had cried on admission, said that “when I saw the impact a good teacher can have on students, I changed my perspective and began to love this faculty” (Current Student FGD, R1).

3.2 RETENTION CHALLENGES

Retention is affected by several interconnected issues. The most frequently cited barrier was negative community attitudes towards teaching. The Dean identified community perception as the greatest challenge:

“The parents invest in their children and want them to earn income in return, that is why they say that teaching has no money.”

DEAN OF THE FACULTY OF EDUCATION, KII

Students reported discouraging remarks such as “Will you always be a teacher?” and “At your age you want to be a teacher and carry a piece of chalk?” (Current Student FGD, R7). One participant admitted concealing the Faculty: “I would cover it up by saying my faculty was my specialization instead of my major” (Current Student FGD, R7).

Financial constraints were the second major barrier. The English Foundation Program, introduced for Batches 11 and 12, adds to existing tuition costs. One student explained that many students come from other states and their families cannot cover the combined costs, suggesting the programme fee should be reduced to around fifty dollars (Current Student FGD, R5). Another described paying fifty dollars in tuition and a further seventy dollars for the English programme a week later, and considering dropping out as a result (Alumni_Current FGD, R11).

Programme length compounded this pressure. Students noted that, having already spent twelve years in school, the additional foundation year reinforced a sense of an extended educational journey (Current Student FGD, R5). The Dean observed that students who begin

dissatisfied often remain disengaged, participate poorly, score below the pass standard, and are likely to drop out (Dean KII).

3.3 POSITIVE INSTITUTIONAL STRENGTHS

Participants also identified clear institutional strengths, and a set of enabling factors that actively encouraged them to stay. Lecturer quality was the most consistently praised feature. One student described the quality of lecturers as the most positive aspect of the programme, noting that staff were highly qualified and supportive throughout (Current Student FGD, R6). Alumni agreed that they had “the best lecturers, including PhD holders”, who advised them on the job market as well as teaching them (Alumni FGD, R4).

Affordability was a second strength. As a publicly funded faculty it does not depend on student contributions, since its budget is provided by government (Dean KII). This mattered particularly for students from lower-income families and from the federal states, who rely on relatives in order to study in Mogadishu.

Orientation and awareness programmes were a third. One student described awareness sessions on future careers, strong school connections, supervised teaching placements and practical classroom experience (Current Student FGD, R2). Teaching practice gave students a concrete sense of the profession and of their own competence within it, while several reported gains in confidence, communication and leadership attributed directly to the programme:

“I realized that this faculty helped me discover a version of myself that I might not have discovered if I had chosen another course.”

CURRENT STUDENT FGD, R1

These enabling factors matter for retention planning because they already exist within the faculty and can be strengthened deliberately rather than built from nothing.

3.4 MOECHE RECRUITMENT DATA ANALYSIS

MoECHE recruitment data for 2023–2024 shows a marked decline in the proportion of successful teaching candidates holding education degrees. In Cohort 1, 13,514 candidates applied for teaching positions across five federal states and 2,801 were successful, of whom

726 (25.9 percent) held education degrees. In Cohort 2, 27,657 applied and 2,361 were successful, but only 226 (9.6 percent) held education degrees. The decline is significant given that many education graduates in Somalia are taking up work outside teaching.

TABLE 1 — MOECHE TEACHER RECRUITMENT BY STATE, COHORT 1 AND COHORT 2 (2023–2024)

State	COHORT 1 (2023)				COHORT 2 (2024)			
	Applied	Passed	Edu. degree	% Edu.	Applied	Passed	Edu. degree	% Edu.
Banaadir	5,042	1,045	352	33.7%	7,696	427	76	17.8%
Galmudug	1,684	457	152	33.3%	2,590	504	47	9.3%
Hirshabeelle	2,142	437	86	19.7%	4,030	411	14	3.4%
Jubaland	2,230	430	70	16.3%	5,516	395	37	9.4%
Koonfur Galbeed	2,416	432	66	15.3%	4,813	418	24	5.7%
Puntland	–	–	–	–	474	0	0	N/A
SSC-Khatumo	–	–	–	–	2,538	206	28	13.6%
Total	13,514	2,801	726	25.9%	27,657	2,361	226	9.6%

Puntland and SSC-Khatumo did not take part in the first recruitment round.

Students and alumni described feeling undervalued by a recruitment system in which MoECHE teaching posts are open to applicants from all academic backgrounds, without specific consideration for graduates holding education degrees. Participants returned repeatedly to the experience of competing for teaching positions against candidates who had no professional preparation in teaching.

“It gives a bad image to the faculty because people can be teaching without qualifications and they don’t have to study for five years.”

ALUMNI FGD, R5

One alumnus described preparing a résumé for a teaching post only to compete against graduates of other faculties, noting that school managers may select cheaper, unqualified candidates. Another observed that engineering and medicine graduates are prioritised within their own fields, while education graduates are disadvantaged because formal qualification is not required in order to teach (Alumni 2 KII).

This points to an opportunity for stronger collaboration between MoECHE and SNU. MoECHE could engage Faculty of Education students directly through recruitment events, career information sessions and school placements, and could consider reserving a proportion of teaching positions for qualified graduates holding education degrees, giving prospective students a visible route from the Faculty into employment.

TABLE 3 — GENDER DISPARITY ANALYSIS ACROSS RECRUITMENT COHORTS

INDICATOR	COHORT 1	COHORT 2
Female applied	1,854 (13.7%)	5,720 (20.7%)
Female passed	236 (8.4%)	746 (31.6%)
Female pass rate	12.7%	13.0%
Male applied	11,660 (86.3%)	21,937 (79.3%)
Male passed	2,565 (91.6%)	1,615 (68.4%)
Male pass rate	22.0%	7.4%

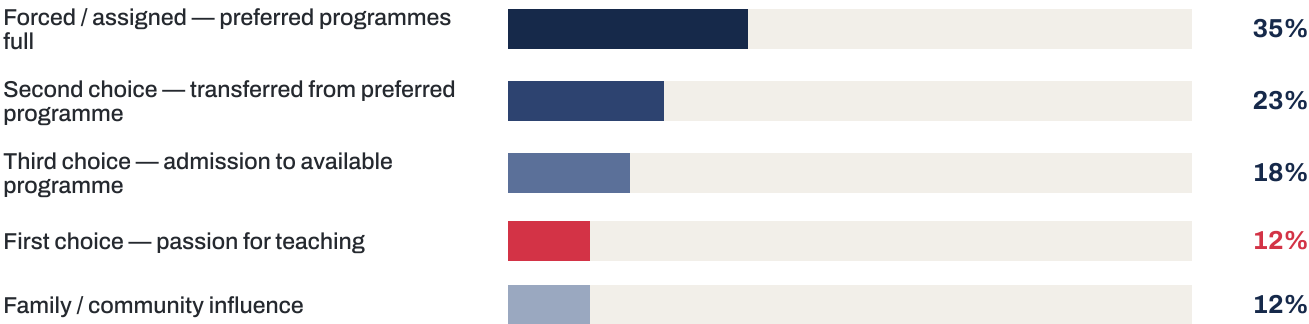
Gender analysis reveals persistent disparities. Men made up 86.3 percent of Cohort 1 applicants and 79.3 percent of Cohort 2, yet women’s pass rates were comparable in Cohort 1 and higher in Cohort 2. Fewer women apply, but those who do are at least as successful as men. The Dean noted that “the Rajo Kaabo program also helped improve our enrolment” (Dean KII), referring to a government scholarship initiative that has supported female students in particular.

This matters for the research question because enrolment and completion cannot be improved without knowing whether male and female students face the same barriers. The shortfall for women sits at the point of application rather than selection, suggesting the binding constraint is reaching the point of applying at all. The interview data is consistent: social discouragement was reported by both, but male students more often described concealing their faculty or presenting it as a minor specialisation, which aligns with See et al.’s (2022) finding that status and prestige weigh more heavily on men. Outreach to women should therefore concentrate on awareness and encouragement to apply, while work with male students should address perceived status and career prospects. This data records applicants for teaching posts rather than applicants to the Faculty, so it indicates the shape of the pipeline rather than enrolment directly.

A university official identified several factors behind the disconnect between education graduates and teaching employment. Students and parents believe that studying Education leads only to classroom teaching, without recognising that graduates also become ministers, directors general and leaders across other sectors; and students compare teaching salaries unfavourably with those in other professions (University Official KII). The recruitment data confirms what participants described: qualified education graduates are not being prioritised for teaching positions, undermining both the attractiveness of the Faculty and the quality of teaching in Somali schools.

FIGURE 2 — STUDENT ENROLLMENT MOTIVATION FOR THE FACULTY OF EDUCATION

Distribution of factors influencing student enrollment choices



4. Literature Synthesis

4.1 INTRINSIC AND ALTRUISTIC MOTIVES

See et al. (2022) identified intrinsic and altruistic motives, such as influencing children and contributing to society, as the main drivers for most teachers. This is consistent with SNU students who developed a passion for teaching after enrolling. The same review found that men weigh external factors such as status, prestige and working conditions more heavily, which helps explain low male participation at SNU and the tendency of male students to present the Faculty as a minor specialisation:

“I would go around and say I was studying my minor and not my faculty.”

CURRENT STUDENT FGD, R7

It also found that women report greater career satisfaction and less social pressure, which may account for stronger retention intentions among female students who do enter Education.

4.2 TEACHER RETENTION AND ATTITUDES TOWARDS TEACHING

Opoku et al. (2025) found that attitude towards teaching is positively associated with retention intention among pre-service teachers in Egypt and the United Arab Emirates. This is consistent with SNU, where students who attended awareness sessions and developed positive attitudes tended to remain:

“The awareness sessions totally changed my outlook. Now I have the quote, ‘My passion and my hobby is teaching’ on my social media.”

CURRENT STUDENT FGD, R7

The study draws on Mason and Matas’ (2015) four-capital retention model, which maps closely onto the SNU findings: social capital in community perceptions, structural capital in resourcing and salaries, human capital in limited practical training, and psychological capital in low motivation and negative self-perception.

4.3 CONFLICT, DISPLACEMENT AND EDUCATION IN THE HORN OF AFRICA

Mousse and Mosisa (2026) found that conflict and displacement negatively affect school enrolment, attendance, grade progression and performance across the Horn of Africa. Chronic teacher shortages and the absence of trauma-sensitive training reduce the quality of education provided, while exposure to violence and forced relocation impairs learning through psychosocial trauma. The review underlines the need for teachers trained to provide psychosocial support in conflict-affected classrooms.

5. Identified Systematic Gaps and Barriers



FIGURE 3 Key barriers affecting student enrolment and retention in teacher education.

Combining the interview data, MoECHE statistics and scholarly literature reveals both convergence and divergence. Negative perceptions of teaching are the clearest point of agreement: See et al. (2022) found status and prestige to matter particularly for men and STEM graduates, and Mohamed (2022) documented the difficulty of attracting and retaining teachers on low salaries. Both are borne out by the interviews.

Resourcing is the second point of agreement. Omar et al. (2025) found that resourcing has the strongest measured effect on the quality of teaching and learning ($\beta = 0.559$), and interviewees consistently reported that SNU lacks the laboratory and library resources it needs.

“I have only done two titration experiments all my studies.”

CURRENT STUDENT FGD — ON THE GAP BETWEEN THEORY AND PRACTICE

The evidence diverges on financial incentives. See et al. (2022) concluded that targeted compensation can encourage entry into teaching but is insufficient for long-term retention, while SNU's Dean and a senior university official both recommended scholarships as a means of attracting students. The difference reflects context: where the literature assumes teachers weighing salary against alternatives, Somali students may forgo education altogether under even small tuition costs, making affordability a question of access rather than of relative reward. The analysis also addresses gaps in the literature, which contains no longitudinal studies of Somali teacher careers, limited evidence on recruitment policy in fragile states, and no assessment of foundation year programmes in teacher preparation.

6. Recommendations



PLATE 2 Combined student and alumni discussion with the research team — the source of several recommendations set out below.

Strengthening Somalia's teaching profession requires coordinated action across institutions rather than action by SNU alone. The recommendations are therefore organised by the body responsible for acting on them, namely MoECHE, Somali National University, and national leadership. In each case, they identify how the institution can contribute to attracting, preparing, recruiting, and retaining strong and qualified teachers across the country.

6.1 MINISTRY OF EDUCATION, CULTURE AND HIGHER EDUCATION

01 Create clearer recruitment pathways for education graduates

Consider reserving a proportion of government teaching positions for candidates holding recognized education degrees, so that professional preparation carries measurable value at the point of recruitment.

02 Strengthen collaboration with SNU

Engage Faculty of Education students directly through recruitment events, career information sessions, internships and school placement opportunities.

03 Recognize professional teacher qualifications

Revise teacher recruitment criteria so that candidates trained specifically for teaching are distinguished from applicants from unrelated disciplines.

04 Support a national teacher certification framework

Work towards certification that prioritizes professionally trained teachers and restricts entry to classroom teaching by unqualified applicants.

6.2 SOMALI NATIONAL UNIVERSITY

01 Strengthen recruitment into the Faculty of Education

Promote teaching as a professional career and communicate available employment pathways to prospective students. A “Future Educators” scheme could engage current students and alumni to visit secondary schools, describe their experience, and set out the range of careers open to education graduates.

02 Develop a targeted regional recruitment strategy

Extend outreach to students across the Federal Member States. Participants from the regions valued the faculty highly but reported limited prior awareness of the programme and the opportunities it offers.

03 Diversify recruitment materials to show varied career paths

Feature graduates who have moved into educational policy, curriculum development, educational leadership and research, and address prevailing perceptions directly through alumni profiles and video.

04 Improve student retention

Extend orientation into a week-long career exploration period with alumni participation and realistic previews of teaching in Somali schools, and provide stronger academic, mentoring and career support to students identified as at risk of leaving.

05 Address financial barriers

Reduce or waive English Foundation Programme fees for Education students, extend scholarship provision along the lines of the Rajo Kaabo programme, and introduce a fee deferral option for students facing temporary hardship.

06 Invest in teaching and learning resources

Renovate and equip the chemistry, biology and physics laboratories, bring the library up to the standard the programmes require, and establish a Teaching Resource Centre.

“If students do not see opportunities after graduation, it becomes difficult to convince them to choose education.”

UNIVERSITY OFFICIAL, KII

6.3 NATIONAL LEADERSHIP

01 Elevate the status of the teaching profession

Position teachers as essential professionals within Somalia’s human capital and national development agenda.

02 Improve teacher incentives

Address salaries, career progression, professional recognition and working conditions as part of efforts to attract talented young people into teaching.

03 Develop a national teacher workforce strategy

Align university teacher preparation, teacher demand, recruitment and long-term workforce planning, so that the number and profile of graduates match the needs of the school system.

7. Conclusion

This analysis reveals that the Faculty of Education at Somali National University faces significant challenges related to negative perceptions of teaching, financial barriers, inadequate infrastructure, and limited career guidance. However, the faculty also has substantial strengths, including quality lecturers, transformative awareness programs, and emerging government employment pathways. The integrated evidence from interviews, Ministry of Education data, and scholarly literature suggests that systemic, multi-pronged interventions are needed to improve recruitment and retention.

The recommendations provided in this report are evidence-informed, contextually appropriate, and practically feasible within the Somali post-conflict context. Priority actions include investing in infrastructure, particularly laboratories and library facilities; launching targeted secondary school outreach campaigns; strengthening alumni engagement and employment pathways; reviewing curriculum and program design; and addressing financial barriers through scholarships and fee reduction.

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